

From Chat to Feelings: Parasocial Relationships as a Bridge Between Social Media and Brand Image Among NCTZen

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Abstract—In the age of digital fandoms, the relationship between idols and fans has transformed into emotionally charged, one-sided connections known as parasocial relationships. This study explores the mediating role of parasocial relationships between social media engagement and brand image among fans of the K-Pop group NCT 127 (NCTZens) in Indonesia and South Korea. Using Lysn, a fandom platform developed by SM Entertainment, this study investigates whether emotionally immersive fan interactions on social media influence perceptions of brands endorsed by idols and PUMA as a case study for brand image evaluation. A quantitative approach was employed, with data collected from 156 respondents through an online survey. Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) was used for hypothesis testing. The results show that social media engagement alone does not significantly foster parasocial relationships, while parasocial relationships significantly influence brand image. However, the indirect effect of social media on brand image through parasocial relationships was found to be insignificant. These findings suggest that while emotional bonds with idols shape brand perception, social media must be strategically curated to sustain meaningful fan engagement. This research provides insights for marketers and entertainment industries on how to leverage fan culture and digital intimacy for brand-building in cross-cultural contexts.

Keywords—Social Media, Parasocial relationships, Brand image, Personalization, K-Pop

I. INTRODUCTION

Today's digitalized society proves that the relationship between celebrities and their audiences has transformed significantly, shifting from the old traditional fan-idol dynamics, once mediated through mass media and distant performances are now deeply shaped by interactive technologies [1], [2]. The emergence of parasocial relationships, a condition described as one-sided emotional attachments from fans toward public figures, has gained renewed attention in this evolving media landscape. Originally introduced in the 1950s by Horton and Wohl [3], parasocial relationships were limited to television and radio personalities. However, with the rise of social media platforms, these relationships have grown more intense, immersive, and influential.

A prime example is the K-Pop Industry, which has strategically leveraged digital tools to foster global fandoms. K-Pop idols are not merely musicians, but curated personalities whose lives, values, and aesthetics are shared and consumed online in real time [4]. As for 2021, Indonesia ranked as the #1 country for K-Pop related tweets, surpassing even South Korea, the birthplace of K-Pop itself [5]. Fandom-driven engagement through platforms like Lysn is reshaping entertainment and global marketing by giving fans exclusive content, personalized messages, and behind-the-scenes access that reinforce the illusion of intimacy [6]. This illusion can become so vivid that some fans feel a personal connection, sometimes leading to blurred boundaries between reality and fantasy [7].

Beyond their emotional implications, parasocial relationships also hold marketing significance, particularly in contexts where fandom loyalty intersects with celebrity endorsements [8]. While the influence of social media on brand image through parasocial relationships has been explored in previous study [9], which it focuses on mainstream platforms, such as YouTube. Although these platforms are interactive, are not purpose-built for intimacy between idols and fans. This study introduces novel contribution by focusing on Lysn, a specialized platform created by SM Entertainment to cultivate parasocial bonding through exclusive access and paid memberships. By exploring Lysn's influence within the parasocial framework, this study offers new insight into how emotionally immersive relationships into brand image, specifically through a case of PUMA, which appointed NCT 127 as its brand ambassador. Moreover, data collected in this research are from NCTzens in both Indonesia and South Korea that introduces a cross-cultural lens into the emotional pathways that lead from Social Media engagement This research addresses the current gaps and answer the question to ***"Is Social Media Influences Brand image Through Parasocial relationships?"***

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

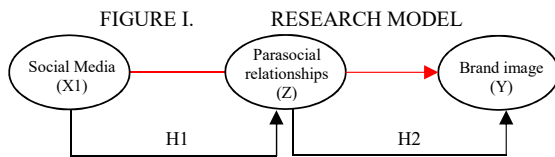
2.1 Theoretical Foundations

Parasocial Relationships were first introduced by Horton and Wohl in 1956 [3] to describe a phenomenon when an individual invests emotions, energy, and time in a one-sided relationship with another party who remains unaware of their

[10] [11]. These relationships create an illusion of intimacy, where audiences feel as if they know the celebrity personally despite the absence of real interaction [12]. Recent studies suggest that social media has amplified parasocial relationships by providing frequent, curated, and seemingly personalized content that deepens fans' emotional investment and perceived closeness with public figures [13][14].

Complementing this, Uses and Gratifications Theory by Blumer and Katz in 1974, which explains that media consumers actively seek contents that fulfill specific psychological needs, such from entertainment until social connection [15]. In the context of K-Pop fandom, especially between NCT 127 fans (NCTZen), fans engage with idol-exclusive content not only for entertainment fulfillment, but also to satisfy their needs for emotional intimacy [6]. This active engagement fosters stronger parasocial relationships and influences their attitudes toward brands endorsed by idols.

Lastly, the Customer-Based Brand Equity or known as CBBE model by Keller in 1993 provides a theoretical lens for understanding how parasocial relationships can be translated to the brand perspective [16] [17] [18]. When fans developed strong parasocial bonds with idols, positive emotions and identification with the idol can be transferred to the brands they endorse, resulting in a more favorable brand image [19].



2.2 Social media

Social media revealed as a strategic branding tool that allows brands and public figures to engage with audiences in real time, while building trust and shape brand perception through personalized content and visual storytelling [20], [21], [22]. In the context of K-Pop, fans actively engage with the brand narrative through reposts, hashtags, and merchandise purchases symbolizing emotional impact. However, most studies focus on general platforms like Instagram or YouTube, while those platforms are not designed to foster controlled intimacy. This study addresses that gap by examining Lysn, a purpose-built platform offering exclusive, curated relationships that may intensify social media's effect on brand image [6]. Ease, trust, and quality are the key indicators for measuring social media [23]. Based on all of the data, the hypothesis constructed is:

H1: Social media significantly influences Brand Image.

2.3 Parasocial relationships

This relationship was first conceptualized by Horton and Wold in 1956 [3], which generate an illusion of intimacy and psychological closeness, enabling audiences to feel as though they know the figure personally despite lack of mutual interaction [whatever]. In the K-Pop ecosystem, such relationships are intensified by exclusive and frequent exposure to idol's curated content through application like Lysn. Empirical studies demonstrate that parasocial relationships are not merely psychological phenomena, but have tangible behavioural outcomes, such as increased of trust, loyalty, and willingness to engage in brand-related behaviors when idols endorse products [24], [25]. When idols

are linked to certain brand, parasocial relationship act as an emotional transfer mechanism that carry a positive effect from the idol to the endorsed brand, enhancing brand image [24], [25]. However, most prior studies have treated parasocial relationships as indirect relationships, with limited application of validate measurement in fandom contexts [19] [25]. To address this gap, this study employs the Measure of Parasocial Relations (MMPR) to capture the intensity and construct hypothesis as below [26]:

H2: Parasocial relationships significantly influence Brand Image.

2.4 Brand image

Previous research has found that the effect of social media on Brand image is not merely functional, but also in the emotional level [20]. [9] emphasize that social media facilitates the formation of parasocial relationships, which then influence fans' attitude. In the entertainment industry, these associations are often transferred from celebrity endorses to the brand, a process explained by the CBBE model that emphasize the role of emotional connections in shaping brand value [16]. For K-Pop fandoms, idols function as cultural symbols, and fans' parasocial relationships with them amplify the perceived authenticity and desirability of endorsed brands. The real example is when NCT 127 collaborate with companies like PUMA, the emotional closeness cultivated through parasocial relationships enhance fans' evaluations of the brand's image. According to [27], corporate image, consumer image, and product image serves as the key indicators in determining brand image. Yet, most studies examine social media's direct effects on brand image while overlooking the mediating role of parasocial relationships, particularly in fandom and cross-cultural contexts. This study will address all the gaps and create a hypothesis;

H3: Social media significantly influences Brand Image through Parasocial Relationships

III. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This study adopted a quantitative approach to examine the relationship between social media, parasocial relationships, and Brand image among fans of NCT 127 (NCTzen) in Indonesia and South Korea.

3.1 Dataset and Sampling

Data were collected using a structured online questionnaire distributed via Google Forms, targeting respondents who actively engage with NCT 127 content are familiar with the Lysn platform. The total sample consisted of 156 valid responses, selected through purposive sampling to ensure relevance to the research context. Given the indeterminate population of NCTzens, a non-probability purposive sampling approach was employed. This method ensured that only individuals meeting the criteria (active NCTzens and understand fashion) were selected. The sample size was justified using the 10-times rule of PLS-SEM with 10 indicators requiring at least 100 observations [28] [29]. This study exceeded this threshold with 156 respondents.

3.2 Data Analysis Technique

To analyze the data, the study applied Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) using SmartPLS 4.0. This method is well-suited for complex models involving latent variables and is particularly robust in

situations with non-normal data distributions and limited sample sizes [30], [31].

The outer model was assessed through measurement model assessment consists of Indicator Loadings and VIF test. The following step is measurement model's reliability and validity test through AVE, Composite Reliability (CR), and Cronbach's Alpha results. The final step is assessing the hypothesis test alongside with Patch Coefficients and Total Effects score [32]. To test the significance of both direct and indirect effects, bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples was conducted. This method is widely used in SEM-PLS for hypothesis testing as it allows for non-parametric estimation, particularly beneficial for non-normally distributed data [33], [34], [35]. Other than that, this research also examine t-test to identify the differences between Indonesian and Korean respondents through SPSS.

3.3 Measurement Items

TABLE I. MEASUREMENT ITEMS

Construct and Measurement Items		Squared Multiple Correlation	Mean	Standard Deviation
Social Media	NCTzens can easily get information through Lysn Application.	0.429	4.115	0.88
	NCTzens can easily access the Lysn Application.	0.418	4.199	0.846
	NCTzens trust the information and news obtained through the Lysn Application.	0.483	4.212	0.811
	NCTzens receive high-quality information through the Lysn Application	0.495	4.141	0.807
Parasocial relationships	NCTzens can feel happy when seeing something related to NCT 127 and feel sad when something bad happens to NCT 127.	0.453	4.583	0.681
	NCTzens follow all updates and imitate movements related to NCT 127.	0.190	4.212	0.803
	NCTzens believe that NCT 127 has extraordinary talent and polite, good attitudes that bring a positive impact on NCTzens.	0.413	4.468	0.731
	NCTzens consider information about NCT 127 when making a purchase decision for a product/service.	0.239	4.263	0.851
Brand image	PUMA has a strong, resilient brand image, blending active sports performance and athletic fashion.	0.412	4.115	0.745
	PUMA consumers are seen as a strong, resilient community of active sports enthusiasts and athletic fashion followers.	0.379	3.853	0.864
	PUMA products are perceived as strong, resilient, symbolizing active sports products with an athletic style.	0.383	4.141	0.838

Notes: Items were measured using Likert-Scale, ranging from 1 to 5 as five-point scale.

3.4 Demographics

Table 2 shows the demographics of the research's respondent of questionnaire. In terms of age distribution, the

majority of respondents fall within the 18–24 age range, making up 71.15% of the total sample. This indicates that most participants are in their late teens to early twenties. Meanwhile, 23.08% of respondents are aged between 25–30 years, and only a small portion are aged 31 and above (3.85%). The youngest age group, 15–17 years old, with the percentage of 1.92%.

Regarding gender, the sample is predominantly female, with 85.26% identifying as such. Males make up only 12.18% of the respondents, and 2.56% preferred not to disclose their gender. From an occupational standpoint, 64.10% of participants are students, making them the largest group in this study. This aligns with the age distribution and supports the assumption that a significant portion of the sample comes from a university or school environment. Additionally, 28.85% of respondents are working professionals, reflecting a considerable portion of individuals already in the workforce. The remaining 7.05% are categorized as freelancers or those currently on a gap year, representing a more flexible and less traditional career path. Overall, the demographic profile of respondents suggests that the study is dominated by young, female students. his composition may influence the generalizability of the findings and should be taken into account when interpreting the results, particularly in contexts involving media consumption or brand perception within specific age and gender groups.

TABLE II. DEMOGRAPHICS DATA AND RESPONDENTS

Characteristics		Frequency	%
Age	15-17	3	1.92%
	18-24	111	71.15%
	25-30	36	23.08%
	31 and above	6	3.85%
Gender	Female	133	85.26%
	Male	19	12.18%
	Prefer not to say	4	2.56%
Occupatio n	Student	100	64.10%
	Professional (Working)	45	28.85%
	Others (Freelancer/Gap Year)	11	7.05%

IV. RESULT

4.1 Measurement Model Assessment

The evaluation of the reflective measurement model begins by assessing the outer loadings of each indicator, as suggested by [32]. According to the commonly accepted threshold of 0.70, indicators with loading values above this are considered reliable, as they explain more than 50% of the variance of the respective latent constructs [32].

Table III. INDICATOR LOADINGS AND VIF

	Social Media	Brand image	Parasocial relationship	VIF
X1.1	0.802			1.751
X1.2	0.788			1.717
X1.3	0.855			1.936
X1.4	0.834			1.981
Y.1			0.825	1.827
Y.2			0.667	1.235
Y.3			0.787	1.704
Y.4			0.711	1.315
Z.1		0.853		1.699
Z.2		0.810		1.609

As shown in table 3, all indicators for Social Media, Parasocial relationships, and Brand image exhibit loading values greater 0.70, indicating acceptable indicators reliability

across all constructs. In addition, the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) test was conducted to examine potential collinearity among indicators. A VIF value above 5 typically signals problematic multicollinearity, while values between 3 and 5 may indicate potential concern [36]. However, values below 3 are generally interpreted as minimal collinearity, and are deemed acceptable for model estimation [37]. Referring to Table 3, all VIF values are below 2, suggesting no collinearity issues exist among the observed indicators, and that the measurement model satisfies reliability and validity standards.

Table IV. MEASUREMENT MODEL'S RELIABILITY AND VALIDITY

	Average Variance (AVE)	Composite Reliability	Cronbach's Alpha
Social Media	0.673	0.851	0.839
Brand image	0.699	0.792	0.752
Parasocial relationship	0.563	0.737	0.737

[32] stated that the second step in evaluating a reflective measurement model involves assessing construct reliability through Composite Reliability (CR). A CR Value between 0.70 and 0.90 indicates satisfactory to good reliability, while values above 0.95 may suggest potential measurement error. Referring from the table 4, all constructs consists of Social Media, Brand image, and Parasocial relationship displays CR values exceeding 0.70, indicating an acceptable level of internal consistency for each constructs. Other than that, Cronbach's Alpha is also used as a traditional reliability indicator, although tis is often more conservative with the same minimum threshold [32]. As shown in the results, all construct meet this criterion, with Cronbach's Alpha values ranging from 0.737 to 0.839 signaling satisfactory reliability across the broad. Lastly, the next phase of measurement model assessment involves evaluating convergent validity, which is tested through Average Variance Extracted (AVE). An AVE value of 0.50 or higher indicates that the construct explains at least 50% of the variance in its indicators [32]. From the table, each construct exceeds the 0.50 threshold, with Parasocial relationship having the lowest AVE of 0.563, still within the acceptable range. Therefore, all constructs demonstrate sufficient convergent validity

4.2 Measurement Model Assessment

Table V. SUMMARY OF HYPOTHESIS TEST, PATH COEFFICIENTS, AND TOTAL EFFECTS

Path	Estimates	Sample Mean	Standard Deviation	T-Value	P-Value	Decision
Social Media → Parasocial relationships	0.081	0.087	0.062	1.308	>0.05	Rejected
Parasocial relationships → Brand image	0.238	0.230	0.108	2.195	*	Accepted
Social Media → Parasocial relationships → Brand image	0.019	0.019	0.017	1.123	>0.05	Rejected

Table 5 indicate that Social Media has negative effect on Parasocial relationships that means direct exposure of Social Media alone does not necessarily enhance the development of Parasocial relationships between fans and idols. Hence, H1 is

rejected. On the other hand, Parasocial relationships significantly influences Brand image. This shows that stronger Parasocial bonds between idols and fans shape how audiences perceive a brand. Thus, H2 is accepted. However, the indirect path from Social Media towards Brand image through Parasocial relationships considered not significant, suggesting that Parasocial Relationships failed to mediate Social Media on Brand image. This leads to the rejection of H3.

4.3 Comparison Between Indonesian and Korean Respondents

Table VI. T-TEST OF INDONESIAN AND KOREAN RESPONDENTS

Variable	Indonesia		Korea		t	df	p-value
	Mean	SD	Mean	SD			
X1.1	3.99	0.95	4.35	0.67	-2.45	154	0.015
X1.2	4.05	0.93	4.47	0.57	-3.06	154	0.003
X1.3	4.08	0.84	4.45	0.69	-2.82	154	0.005
X1.4	4.10	0.84	4.22	0.74	-0.88	154	0.190
Z.1	4.56	0.75	4.62	0.53	-0.47	154	0.639
Z.2	4.11	0.84	4.38	0.70	-1.97	154	0.050
Z.3	4.49	0.76	4.41	0.65	0.62	154	0.532
Z.4	4.19	0.90	4.38	0.73	-1.29	154	0.198
Y.1	3.99	0.80	4.34	0.55	-2.91	154	0.004
Y.2	3.78	0.94	3.98	0.68	-1.38	154	0.169
Y.3	3.99	0.87	4.41	0.68	-3.13	154	0.002

The independent t-test was conducted to examine differences between Indonesian and Korean respondents across all constructs. As shown in Table VI, X1.1, X1.2, X1.3, Y1, and Y3 showed significant mean differences ($p < 0.05$) [38], with Korean respondents reporting consistently higher scores compared to Indonesian respondents. Other variables did not show significant differences, indicating relatively similarly perception across both groups.

V. DISCUSSION

5.1 The Influence of Social Media on Parasocial relationships

The research results indicate that Social media has a negative relationships towards Parasocial relationships, resulted from the hypothesis test, where H1 is being rejected and H0 is being accepted, as the P-Value is greater than the standard. This outcome contradicts previous research done by [22] that suggested a positive relationship between the two variables. Following that, researcher conducted interviews with questionnaire respondents to identify the reason behind the negative relationship within the variables. Quoted from respondent Ms. A, "*Lysn inhibits parasocial relationship between NCTzen and NCT 127 around 60% due to paid subscriptions, exclusive content being scattered around other social media, and language barrier.*" Similarly, Ms. M and Z noted a decline in their emotional connection due to leaked content and reduced perceived authenticity.

These responses suggest that the effectiveness of social media in fostering parasocial relationships is heavily perceived by the value and authenticity of the platform. When fans encounter barriers and limitations, the illusion of intimacy that defines parasocial relationships is disrupted. This aligns with the Uses and Gratifications Theory, which posits that media effects depend on users' ability to satisfy psychological and social needs. This study highlights that the relationship between social media and parasocial relationships is conditional, where it stronger on open and interactive

platforms, but weaker on controlled, monetized, or fragmented platforms like Lysn.

5.2 The Influence of Parasocial relationship on Brand image

The calculation resulted in positive relationships between parasocial relationships on Brand image, as indicated by a p-value of 0.028 (<0.05), thereby supporting the proposed hypothesis. This confirms that emotional bonds formed through parasocial relationships between NCTzens and NCT 127 enhance the perception of brand's image. This aligns with [3] [12], concept of parasocial relationships, where the illusion of intimacy extends beyond psychological attraction to shape consumer behavior. Cited from [24] crafting parasocial relationships is very crucial, especially in creating brand image. It is known as those celebrities can create a parasocial relationships bond between them and their fans. To ensure that the brand image reflects their company identity, it's important to choose the right celebrities that can represent brand's campaign. This assertion validates that parasocial relationships play a meaningful role in influencing a brand's image.

5.3 The Influence of Social Media on Brand image through Parasocial relationships

The research results indicate that social media has a negative relationship with Brand image when mediated by Parasocial relationships. This could be seen when H1 is rejected, and H0. This suggests that while Lysn enable idols to promote products through these interactions do not necessarily reshape fans' deeper brand perceptions. Interview support this interpretation. Ms. M, explained: *"When I see PUMA, it's just PUMA. But, ever since NCT 127 is the Brand Ambassador of PUMA, I pay attention when they promote it through Lysn and intend to buy it because of them. Aside from that, my perception towards PUMA's Brand image doesn't change."* Similarly, Ms. Z and Ms. W noted that PUMA remains *"just another shoe brand"* despite the idol endorsement.

According to Horton and Wohl [3], parasocial relationships depends on the sustained illusion of intimacy. On Lysn, this illusion may weaken due to subscription costs, fragment content, language barriers, which reduce fans' perception of authentic closeness. From the perspective of Uses and Gratifications Theory, fans' primary motivation for engaging are when they men their emotional connection and entertainment needs, when these gratifications are not fully ment, the relational parasocial may not extend into brand-level associations. Lastly, through CBBE perspective, Puma's brand identity appears relatively stable and independent, but do not modify a deeper symbolic dimensions of brand image through all the constraints mentioned. This result highlights the boundary conditions, showing that while such relationships can generate attention, they do not necessary alter deeper brand associations or identity.

5.4 Difference Between Indonesian and Korean Respondents

The comparison between Indonesia and Korean respondents shows notable differences between variables. In social media, Korean fans scored higher in ease (X1.1), usage (X1.2), and trust (X1.3), suggesting they find Lysn more convenient, use them more actively, and have greater confidence in the interactions provided which are inline with uses and gratifications theory. The theory explain that

audiences actively use media to fulfill needs for convenience, habitual connection, and reliability [15]. Similarity happened with quality (X1.4), both groups evaluate Lysn in the same way, due to standardized nature of global K-pop content

In parasocial relationships, Indonesian and Korean did not differ significantly, suggesting that parasocial relationships grow in similar ways. However, for brand image, decision (Y.3) was significant was significantly higher among Korean respondents which align with CBBE model that highlights emotional connections can translate into brand-related decisions [16]. In this case, Korean has stronger cultural and language alignment that may help convert parasocial closeness into actual brand decisions compared to Indonesian. Overall, the findings suggest that parasocial relationships operate universally across the countries, but the extent to which they influence brand outcomes is shaped by local context.

VI. CONCLUSION

This study explored the role of parasocial relationships in mediating the influence of social media on Brand image among NCTZens in Indonesia and South Korea. Drawing upon the context of the K-Pop group NCT 127 and their fans. First, the result revealed that social media usage alone does not significantly influence the development of parasocial relationships that fandom-driven platform like Lysn deals with external factors. Second, parasocial relationships were found to have a significant positive impact on Brand image. This proves that fans feel emotionally connected to NCT 127 were more likely to perceive PUMA in a more desirable way. Third, the indirect path from social media to brand image via parasocial relationships was not significant. This suggest that while parasocial experiences may influence brand awareness, they do not necessarily alter overall brand perception. Lastly, Indonesian and Korean respondents both developed similar parasocial relationships, but Korean showed higher ease, usage, trust and stronger brand-related decisions on Lysn.

In conclusion, the findings emphasize that parasocial relationships play a critical and direct role in enhancing brand image, especially in the dynamic of fan-centric digital ecosystems. However, social media usage must be strategically designed and culturally sensitive to foster meaningful connections with avoiding issues such as leaked of data and other global issues like translation. These insights are particularly valuable for marketers and entertainment agencies seeking to leverage fan loyalty in cross-cultural contexts. Future research is encouraged to further explore platform-specific engagement strategies, their long-term branding effects across different fandom cultures, and dive deeper into the cultural differences that affect the Indonesian and Korean fans behave.

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